

* South China Sea :-

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* Geo - Economic importance :-

- i) Annually the trade of worth \$ 3.4 trillion passes through South China Sea. This itself shows that Centre of Gravity in Economic Sphere lies in South China Sea. Asia's most Economically Dynamic Region.
- ii) Besides trade it is expected to have allow around :-
 - a) 11 bn barrels of Oil
 - b) 190 trillion Cubic Ft of Gas.

Besides Fish Stock, Coral and other under Sea Resources.

• Significance for India in Geo-Economic Sense :-

Almost 50% of India's trade with outside world is located / goes through this Region. So far India has FTA with only one Regional Organisation i.e. Asian. Hence, it is obvious for India to have stakes in the stability of the Region and to ensure that sea lines of communication are free for the purpose of Un-impeded / Seamless trade.

As India's Energy demands are growing and there are Uncertainties in West Asia and Connectivity issues in Central Asia. It makes sense for India b/c of proximity to source Oil and Gas from the Region.

India has been working ⁱⁿ Partnership with Vietnam for Exploration of Oil and Gas.

* Geo-Strategic Importance / Scenario :- (Security Related)

The Region is connected to Indian Ocean in Maritime Domain, South China Sea and Indian Ocean form an integrated Entity, Thus the Challenges like - Piracy, Terrorism, Drug-Trafficking, Natural Disaster, Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons bound to Create Security Concerns.

India and South East Asia are also connected via-land; hence Stability in the Region has direct Consequences for India's own Frontiers (North-East).

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* Geo-Political Importance :- (Balance of Power).

From the perspective of Geo-Politics, Asia Pacific has become the most critical Geography b/c of "Power Transitions" (Kenneth Organski) - which implies the possibility of war.

Scholar like - Graham Allison talk about the possibility of Thucy Dides Trap.

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A term used very often to predict the prospects of US-China Relations.

As per the Concept, there is always a probability of war b/w Status Quoist power and Revisionist Power.
(U.S.) (China).

The Concept of Thucy Dides trap was initially given by the Greek Scholar - Thucy Dides. In his book - "The History of Peloponnesian War"

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A sort of a world war where all city states were involved.

There were two leagues! -

a) Athens — Revisionist Power.

b) Sparta — Status - Quoist Power.

The war Ended in the victory of Sparta.

The theory suggest that in most of the situation weaker party starts the war.

Even John Mearsheimer, predicts the possibility of war b/w US and China. In his book — "The tragedy of Great Power Politics"

Considering the developments in the region, we can't avoid the probability of war. Taiwan is the most probable Flashpoint. b/w US & China.

Q) Whether China wants war in Taiwan at present? -
- No, not at all.

Why? -

- B/c it is out of their strength.

The maximum China can do is — "War of Words".

i) The lesson of Ukraine is in front of China. Russia started war but it does not have scope for Graceful exit.

This is the time when China is projecting its image as peacemaker and peace-builder. Hence, it will be very out of place & out of time. to take Taiwan Militarily.

What is China's Policy? -

- Buy time. It means China is waiting for the time by which USA's enthusiasm or appetite to secure its interest becomes faint.

China is waiting for the time where it gets definite superiority. As of now China is building Deterrence.

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What China want? -

Taiwan should not seek independent.

What Taiwan want? -

Its Security should not get breached.

What U.S. wants?

i) Taiwan should not go under Chinese Control.

ii) At the same time, Taiwan should not seek complete independence.

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This will definitely result into war. U.S. also has Economic interest in China, the only thing is China follows rule of the Game. China observes rule of law w/c has been framed by the West/Jewist.

The defining idea of Free and Open Indo-Pacific is rule-based order.

Since the Economies of the countries are so much inter-dependent, Non- of the Stakeholder would prefer War. However, there is always a possibility of war in International politics.

Even USA is taking Action to "Dissuade China" from any such Action.

What is the difference in to ^{deter}~~deter~~ and to dissuade? -

Deter means to prevent a country from committing aggression.

Dissuade means to ~~convince~~ convince the country that war is not an option. It means to end the willingness to go for war.

Q) What is U.S. policy towards Taiwan? -

It is called as policy of strategic ambiguity.

It means not

giving clear picture.

It is not clear whether U.S. will intervene militarily in case China tries to take Taiwan by force.

Why? -

Unlike Japan, S. Korea, Philippines, ~~there is no security~~ ~~Go~~ which are allies of U.S., for which there are clear guarantees, there are no such commitments for Taiwan.

Why USA maintain Strategic Ambiguity? -

- i) So that Taiwan does not declare independence. (No explicit commitment for defence).
- ii) So that China does not attack Taiwan - hence US never denies that it will not come for China's defence.

Why USA maintains Strategic Ambiguity? -

i) B/c US has economic interest in both the state.

U.S. wants flexibility.

For E.g. 1- USA needed China against USSR, it may need China against India. It also needed China against Japan.

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What India wants? -

India wants peace and stability, and resolution of dispute in a peaceful manner. In no situation, India would prefer balance of power to shift distinctively in favour of China. Hence, India is working with like-minded countries to ensure the balance. India is part of QUAD and has not been critical of AUKUS.

Recently, India has voted against a resolution sponsored by China and Russia at IAEA w/c aimed to show that AUKUS w/c involves the deal for the transfer of Nuclear propelled submarine as a violation of NPT.

What is the dispute in South China Sea? -

There is a dispute b/w US and China over the interpretation of the rules under UN Convention on laws of Seas (UNCLOS)

UNCLOS categorises the waters into different zones.

- i) Territorial Zones - 12 Nautical Miles.
- ii) Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) - 200 Nautical Miles.

What is China's interpretation ? -

China believes that there is no absolute Freedom of Navigation in EEZ.

Other countries can't send Naval ships or conduct Military Exercises in EEZ w/o permission.

What is USA's interpretation ?

EEZ only restrict other countries from Economic Exploration or use of wealth but it was never meant to prevent other activities including Naval activities.

It is to be noted that China is a party to UNCLOS but it does not observe the rules. On the other hand, US is not a party but enforces the rules.

U.S. conducts Freedom of Navigation Operations (**FONOPS**) to ensure that countries abide with UNCLOS.

Why there is a dispute ? -

B/c US aims at containment of China.

How ? -

Collapse of Communist party of China and China to become Democratic.

USA has contained China Militarily in the East by its Hub and spoke system. It means there are US Military bases in the Region.

What China is doing? -

Initially, China asserted that there can't be the presence of other countries Military in EEZ, but now China wants entire South China Sea w/c it demarcates as 9-dash line as China's Territorial Waters.

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Earlier Taiwan also made ^{similar} claims w/c they called as 10-dash line.

What is the problem? -

It will prevent all other countries to have freedom of Trade and Commerce considering South China Sea is the heart of the Region.

What are Chinese Activities? -

China is laying the claims over the Islands in South China Sea.

i) China has occupied Paracel Island since 1974.

Party in dispute is - China, Taiwan & Vietnam (North SCS).

ii) Spratly Island in South.

- Most of the island are under Vietnam but China has also occupied.

Parties in conflict - China, Taiwan & Vietnam. & it also include Brunei, Malaysia, Philippines.

iii) Scarborough Shoal (Eastern SCS)

- Parties in conflict are - China, Taiwan & Philippines.

China has occupied the islands. In 2012, Philippines approached to Permanent Court of Arbitration, w/c gave its verdict in 2016 rejected Chinese claims, However, China rejected the Verdict.

Hence, China is accused of not observing the rule of law.

- i) Thus challenging / Destroying the liberal International Order.
- ii) China is also building Artificial Island to increase its claims. Though UNCLOS does not recognise artificial Islands. Artificial Islands have impact on the Marine Ecosystem. Thus China is creating Non-Conventional Security Threats.
- iii) China is Militarising the Occupied Islands and the artificial Islands and this include the establishing Air bases Surveillance System, Missiles and Even Nuclear weapons. Thus, China is increasing Nuclear Arms Race in the Region and threatening the Security Environment.
- iv) China's Action are not limited to Maritime sphere, it is also restricting Freedom of Skies. It goes for Unilateral Declaration of ADIZ, (Air Defence Identification Zone). Specifically in East China Sea where it has dispute over Senkaku Island / Diaoyu Island with Japan and Taiwan.

How India comes into picture? -

- Its Complicated.

What is Politics behind contestation over Taiwan? -

Taiwan is located very near to China's mainland. Hence, the presence of US in around Taiwan is always a cause of concern b/c US can block China's access to South China Sea.

China can be Choked here.

• What China wants? -

To establish its Military presence in Taiwan.

• What will be the Consequence? -

i) Collapse of USA's plan to choke China's access to the outside world.

ii) If China is successful to occupy Taiwan, it will be a great loss of credibility for US, its game will be over in the Region b/c allies will not trust its Capabilities.

iii) Once Taiwan is under China, China will set up its Nuclear weapons in Taiwan. Thus, bringing US military bases in the Region under the closest to danger Zone.

iv) Even USA will have to shift further in the East to protect its Armed Forces.

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* History of US-Taiwan Relations :-

- i) In 1949, US supported govt. of Chiang Kai shek had to shift to Taiwan.
US didn't recognise Communist China.
- ii) In 1971, UNGA passed a Resolution to replace RoC (Republic of China) by PRC (Peoples Republic of China) as a P-5.

Why? -

- B/c US needed China against Russia and Japan

- iii) In 1979, US estd. unofficial Relations with Taiwan.
USA brought Taiwan relations Act in 1979 w/c governed their Relations. By w/c US is committed not to allow integration by force. For this, US will provide Defence Equipments and Services needed for Taiwans Self Defence.
Otherwise US recognise Taiwan as Part of China under 3 Communiqués i.e. 1972, 78, 82.

- iv) In 1982, USA offered 6 assurances to Taiwan :-
 - a) They will not stop the Arms sale.
 - b) They will not consult with China in Arm sales to Taiwan.
 - c) They will not mediate in the Conflict.
 - d) They will not revoke Taiwan - Relations Act.
 - e) No pressure on Taiwan to Compromise.
 - f) will not allow Gersion that puts Taiwans system under Threat.

v) In 2005, China passed "Anti-Secession law"



If Taiwan declares independence
China will intervene by Force.

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vi) Oct 2022, — Xi-Jinping declared 2027 as the year
to integrate Taiwan. Most important aspect of
addressing the Humiliation.

US brought Taiwan Policy Act in 2022.

- a) In Case of Coersion, there will be Sanctions.
- b) Taiwan as major Non-Nato ally.
- c) Has given \$4.5 bn for Defence Capacity building.
- d) Taiwan will be brought in International Platforms.

NOTE!-

↳ Policy of S. Korea is called as New Southern
Policy.

Policy of Taiwan is called as ^{New} South Bound Policy.